

Tis the season to be jolly

or – the elephant in the room

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Human societies take drugs to change the way they feel

Denial at the individual and institutional level

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Terminology

- Excessive consumption
- Alcohol abuse
- Alcohol dependency (alcoholism)
- Other terms e.g. hazardous/harmful use

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General Lifestyle Survey (2008) – ONS

- ▶ 71% men & 56% women drank on at least 1 day in week before survey
- ▶ 28% men & 19% women exceeded recommended weekly intake
- ▶ 22% men & 15% women took >8/6 units on 1 day in week before survey
- ▶ 7% men & 5% women took >50/35 units in week before survey

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- ▶ 6,769 deaths directly related to alcohol in 2008 (24% increase from 2001)
(Mainly cirrhosis of the liver and so large underestimate)

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- ▶ Prevalence of alcohol dependency –very difficult to estimate, but could be over 5% of the population

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Physical effects of excess alcohol intake

▶ GI

- Gastritis and peptic ulcer
- Hepatitis and cirrhosis
- Acute and chronic pancreatitis
- Oesophageal cancer

▶ Neurological

- Peripheral neuropathy
- Cerebellar degeneration
- Epilepsy

▶ Other

- Cardiomyopathy
- Obesity
- Nutritional deficiencies
- Accidents

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Mental health effects of excess alcohol intake

- ▶ Intoxication
- ▶ Withdrawal states
 - Delirium tremens
 - Alcoholic hallucinations
- ▶ Toxic and nutritional states
 - Wernicke's encephalopathy
 - Korsakov's syndrome
- ▶ Associated states
 - Depression
 - Anxiety
 - Suicide and self harm
 - Personality change

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Alcohol Dependency – Alcoholism

- ▶ Disease or willpower
- ▶ Causes
 - Family history
 - Twin studies
 - Sons of alcoholic fathers
 - Adverse life experience
 - Drinking alcohol
 - Combine in different ways to cause different patterns of onset and different patterns of drinking

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Features of Dependency

- ▶ Increasing importance of alcohol and associated behaviour
- ▶ Altered tolerance
- ▶ Reduced drinking repertoire
- ▶ Withdrawal symptoms
- ▶ Resumption of drinking after abstinence despite knowledge of harmful effects

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Withdrawal Symptoms

- ▶ Shakes
- ▶ Nausea and retching
- ▶ Diarrhoea
- ▶ Sweating
- ▶ Misperception/ hallucinations/DTs

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Patterns of behaviour and absence to raise suspicions

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Confirming the Suspicion

- ▶ Ask
- ▶ But don't just ask
- ▶ Ensure that all parties recognise the elephant

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Screening Tools

▶ CAGE

- Criticised
- Annoyed
- Guilty
- Eye Opener

▶ MAST

- 22 point questionnaire

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Treatment

► Controlled Drinking

- Drinking diaries
- Drugs
 - Antabuse
 - Acamprosate
 - Naltrexone

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Treatment

- ▶ Dependence = abstinence
- ▶ Detoxification
- ▶ Support – in patient v out patient
 - Deal with the denial
 - Look for causes from within
- ▶ Self help – Alcoholics Anonymous and 12 Step Programme

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Treatment

- ▶ Progress requires acceptance
 - “Yes but -----”
 - Relapse is to be expected

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Issues for Employers

- ▶ Need to recognise that the elephant is there
- ▶ Drug/alcohol policies
- ▶ Health v. conduct/disciplinary issue
- ▶ Drug and alcohol policies
- ▶ Corporate culture in relation to alcohol
- ▶ Recognise when someone is doing the right things
 - But recognise that full recovery takes time.
 - Adaptations to recognise where the person is in recovery e.g. travel

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Other Addictive Drugs

- ▶ Illegal v prescription drugs – people with alcohol problems are often prescribed other addictive drugs (opiates, benzodiazepines)
- ▶ Other drugs will have their individual physical and psychological adverse effects
- ▶ But addiction is addiction